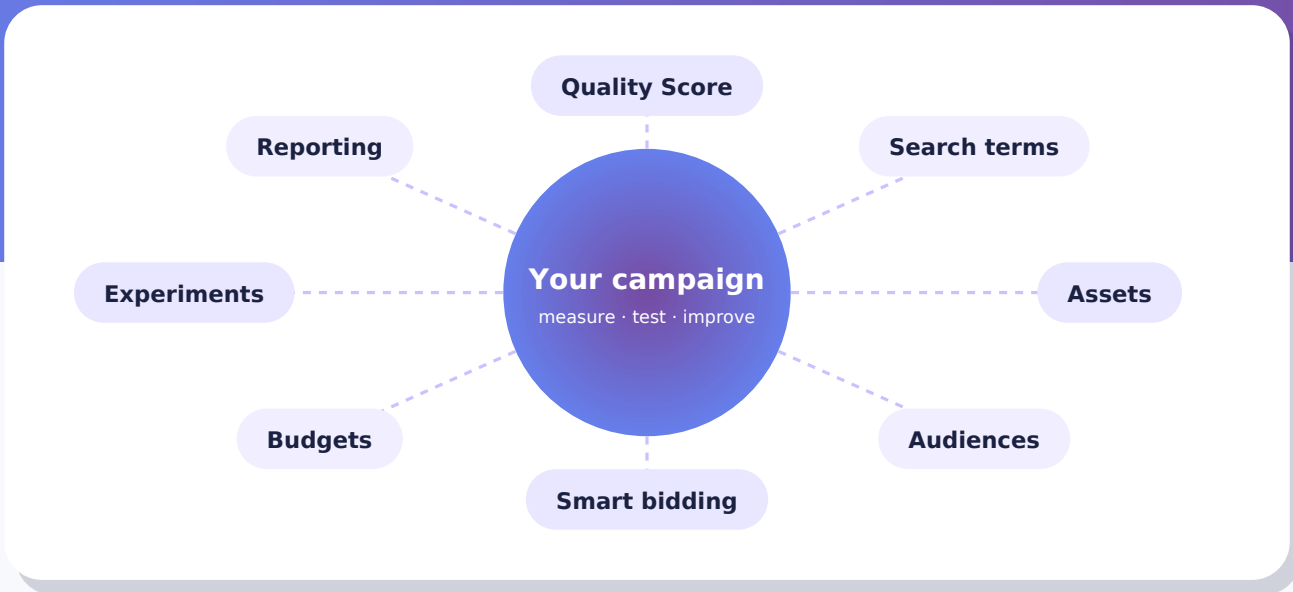
WEEK 7 · DIGITAL MARKETING & AI BOOTCAMP

Google Ads: Advanced Search & Optimisation

Quality Score, assets, audiences, bidding and audits for businesses in Mauritius, step by step

Avinesh Bundhoo & Fareez Fawdar · Oreegami Mauritius · October 2026



Inside this guide

1 From launching to optimising
2 Metrics and formulas
3 How Ad Rank works
4 Quality Score explained
5 Google Ads in Mauritius
6 Targets that make money
7 An easy-to-optimise structure
8 Conversion tracking you can trust
9 Consent and privacy
10 Improving expected CTR
11 Improving ad relevance
12 Improving landing page experience
13 Search terms and negatives
14 Ad strength and asset performance
15 Assets: every type explained
16 Assets: best practice and setup
17 Audiences in Search
18 Setting up remarketing lists
19 Smart bidding optimisation
20 Budgets, pacing, impression share
21 Schedule, device and location
22 Experiments (A/B tests)
23 Recommendations and optimisation score
24 Performance Max and AI Max
25 Reporting and Data Studio
26 The account audit checklist
27 Routine and governance
28 Case study: a car rental company
29 Exercises and Performance Audit
30 Checklists and glossary

PART A

Foundations

From launching campaigns to optimising them: metrics, Ad Rank and Quality Score

SECTION 1

From launching to optimising

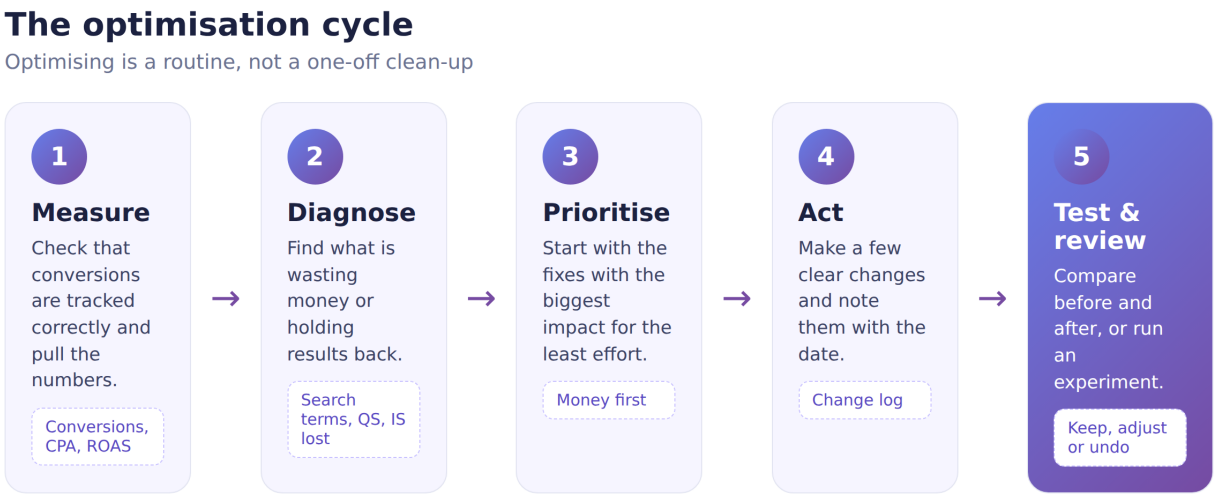
In Week 6 you learnt to build a Google Ads account: campaign types, account structure, keywords and match types, responsive search ads (RSAs) and the basics of bidding. This week is about what happens next. A campaign is never "finished" on launch day: the best results come from weeks of careful measuring, testing and improving.

Quick recap of Week 6

Topic	What you should already know
Account structure	Account → campaigns (budget, location, language, bidding) → ad groups (one theme) → keywords and ads
Match types	Broad, phrase and exact match, and how each controls which searches can trigger your ad
Responsive search ads	Up to 15 headlines (30 characters) and 4 descriptions (90 characters) that Google combines
Bidding basics	Manual CPC, Maximise clicks, Maximise conversions and the idea of a target
Conversion tracking	Why a conversion (booking, lead, call, purchase) must be tracked before you spend seriously

What "optimisation" really means

Optimisation means getting **more of the results you want for the same money**, or the same results for less money. It is not about making the account look busy. A good optimiser makes a few well-chosen changes, measures them, and keeps only what works.



The three levers you can pull

- **Spend less on waste:** irrelevant searches, wrong locations, bad hours, weak keywords (Sections 13 and 21).
- **Win better auctions:** higher Quality Score, stronger ads and assets, so you pay less per click and show higher (Sections 10 to 16).
- **Convert more of your clicks:** better landing pages, better offers, better audiences and smarter bidding (Sections 12, 17 to 19).

> **The golden rule:** never optimise blind. If conversion tracking is wrong, every decision based on CPA or ROAS is wrong too. That is why the audit in Section 26 starts with tracking.

This week’s deliverable

You will produce a **Performance Audit**: a campaign optimisation report for a real or realistic account, with Quality Score improvements and a ROAS (return on ad spend) analysis. Section 29 explains it step by step, and the Excel exercise lets you practise every calculation.

SECTION 2

The metrics and formulas you must master

Every optimisation decision uses a small set of numbers. You saw some of them in Week 1 and Week 2. Here they are again, in the form Google Ads uses them.

The eight numbers every optimiser uses

Learn them by heart: every decision in this guide uses them

CTR
Click-through rate
Clicks ÷ impressions × 100
120 ÷ 4,000 = 3.0%

CPC
Cost per click
Cost ÷ clicks
Rs 3,600 ÷ 120 = Rs 30

CVR
Conversion rate
Conversions ÷ clicks × 100
6 ÷ 120 = 5.0%

CPA
Cost per acquisition
Cost ÷ conversions
Rs 3,600 ÷ 6 = Rs 600

ROAS
Return on ad spend
Revenue ÷ cost
Rs 18,000 ÷ 3,600 = 5.0 (500%)

ROI
Return on investment
(Gross profit − cost) ÷ cost × 100
(7,200 − 3,600) ÷ 3,600 = 100%

IS
Search impression share
Impressions ÷ eligible impressions × 100
4,000 ÷ 10,000 = 40%

BREAK-EVEN
Break-even ROAS
1 ÷ profit margin
Margin 40% → ROAS 2.5

Worked example: one ad group, one month

Data from Google Ads	Value	Calculation	Result
Impressions	20,000	CTR = 900 ÷ 20,000 × 100	4.5%
Clicks	900	CPC = Rs 27,000 ÷ 900	Rs 30
Cost	Rs 27,000	CVR = 18 ÷ 900 × 100	2.0%
Conversions (bookings)	18	CPA = Rs 27,000 ÷ 18	Rs 1,500
Conversion value (revenue)	Rs 162,000	ROAS = 162,000 ÷ 27,000	6.0 (600%)
Gross margin	35%	Gross profit = 162,000 × 35%	Rs 56,700
		ROI = (56,700 − 27,000) ÷ 27,000 × 100	110%

ROAS or ROI: what is the difference?

ROAS compares revenue with ad cost. It is easy to read in Google Ads (the "Conv. value / cost" column) but it ignores your costs of delivering the product. **ROI** (return on investment) uses profit, so it tells you whether the advertising really made money. A ROAS of 3 can be excellent for a business with a 60% margin and a loss for a business with a 20% margin.

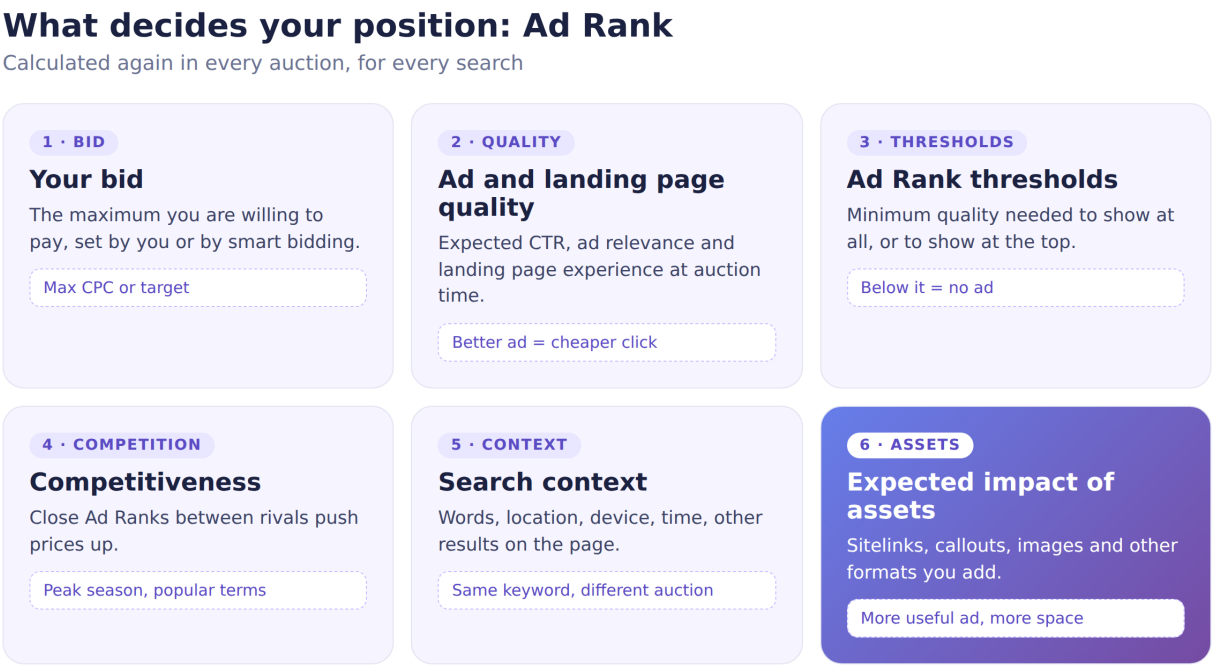
Metric	Formula	Shown in Google Ads as
CTR	Clicks ÷ impressions × 100	CTR
Average CPC	Cost ÷ clicks	Avg. CPC
Conversion rate (CVR)	Conversions ÷ clicks × 100 (Google divides by interactions)	Conv. rate
CPA	Cost ÷ conversions	Cost / conv.
ROAS	Conversion value ÷ cost	Conv. value / cost
ROI	(Gross profit − ad cost) ÷ ad cost × 100	Not shown: calculate it yourself
Search impression share	Impressions ÷ estimated eligible impressions × 100	Search impr. share
Break-even ROAS	1 ÷ gross margin	Not shown: calculate it yourself
Break-even CPA	Average order value × gross margin	Not shown: calculate it yourself

> **Tip:** ROAS is sometimes written as a ratio (5.0, or 5:1) and sometimes as a percentage (500%). Google Ads uses the percentage when you set a target ROAS. They mean the same thing: Rs 5 of revenue for every Rs 1 of ad cost.

SECTION 3

How the auction ranks ads: Ad Rank

Every time someone searches on Google, an auction decides which ads appear and in which order. Your position is decided by **Ad Rank**, which is calculated fresh for every single search.



Why quality beats money

Google's help centre lists six things that feed Ad Rank: your bid, the quality of your ads and landing page, Ad Rank thresholds, the competitiveness of the auction, the context of the search and the expected impact of your assets. Because quality is part of the calculation, a business with a very relevant ad and a good landing page can show above a competitor that bids more. Google also says that higher-quality ads often lead to lower costs per click.

What you actually pay

You rarely pay your full maximum bid. In general you pay what is needed to beat the Ad Rank of the advertiser below you, and Google says higher-ranking ads may pay more when the gap is large. The practical lesson: improving quality is the only way to get a better position **and** a lower price at the same time.

Ad Rank thresholds

Thresholds are minimum Ad Rank levels. Below the minimum, your ad does not show at all. Higher thresholds apply for the top positions above the organic results. That is why a low-quality ad can have a high bid and still get very few impressions at the top of the page.

> **In Mauritius:** in a small market, many keywords have only a few advertisers, for example "4x4 rental Rodrigues" or "wedding photographer Grand Baie". With little competition, thresholds and quality matter more than the bid. A clean, relevant ad can win the top spot for a few rupees per click.

SECTION 4

Quality Score explained

Quality Score is Google's 1–10 rating of how relevant and useful your ads and landing pages are for a keyword, compared with other advertisers. It is shown for each keyword in Search campaigns.

Quality Score: three components, three fixes

Each component is rated Above average, Average or Below average



A diagnostic tool, not the auction itself

This is a common misunderstanding. Google states that Quality Score is a **diagnostic tool** and is **not an input in the ad auction**. In the auction Google uses real-time quality signals for each search. Quality Score summarises those signals over time so you can see where to improve. Treat it like the warning lights on a car dashboard: it tells you where to look, not exactly what happened in each auction.

How Quality Score is calculated

Each of the three components is rated **Above average**, **Average** or **Below average**, compared with other advertisers whose ads showed for exactly the same search over the last 90 days. The combination gives the 1–10 score. A keyword shows "—" (no score) when there are not enough exact searches for it, which is common in Mauritius.

How to see it in your account

1. Go to **Campaigns → Audiences, keywords and content → Search keywords**.
2. Click the **columns** icon above the table, then **Modify columns**.
3. Open the **Quality Score** section and tick Quality Score, Landing page exp., Exp. CTR and Ad relevance.
4. Optionally add the "(hist.)" versions to see the values for your chosen date range.
5. Click **Apply**, then sort by cost so you look first at the keywords that spend the most.

Reading the score

Score	What it usually means	What to do
1–4	At least one component is Below average, often two	Fix urgently if the keyword spends money: check the ad group theme and landing page
5–6	Mixed: some components Average	Find the weakest component and improve it
7–10	Good to excellent relevance	Keep it, protect it, test new ads carefully
—	Not enough exact-search data	Judge the keyword on CTR, CVR and CPA instead

Weighted Quality Score

A simple average of Quality Scores can mislead you because a keyword with 10 impressions counts as much as one with 10,000. Professionals calculate a **weighted Quality Score**: multiply each keyword's score by its impressions, add them up and divide by total impressions. In Excel: =SUMPRODUCT(scores, impressions) ÷ SUM(impressions). You will do this in the Excel exercise.

> Do not chase a perfect 10 on every keyword. A keyword with Quality Score 5 and a CPA well below target is a good keyword. Quality Score is a guide to cheaper clicks, not a goal in itself.

SECTION 5

Google Ads in Mauritius

Optimising an account in Mauritius is different from optimising one in a large market. Volumes are smaller, audiences are mixed (residents and tourists) and searches happen in several languages.

Key facts

Fact	What it means for optimisation
Google had about 90% of the search market in Mauritius in September 2026 (StatCounter, all platforms); Bing about 8%	Google Ads reaches almost every searcher. Microsoft Advertising can be a small extra channel later.
Small search volumes	Many keywords show "Low search volume" or no Quality Score. Group similar keywords and judge results over longer periods (4–8 weeks).
Residents and tourists	A hotel or car rental advertises to people abroad (France, Réunion, the UK, South Africa, India…) as well as locally. Location settings matter a lot (Section 21).
English, French and Kreol	Residents often search in French or English; Kreol searches exist but are usually short. Tourists from France and Réunion search in French.
Mobile-first	Most searches happen on phones. Landing pages, call assets and WhatsApp buttons must work perfectly on mobile.
WhatsApp and calls	Many "conversions" are a WhatsApp message or a phone call. Track them (Section 8) or Google cannot optimise for them.

Typical Mauritian search campaigns

Business	Example keywords	Main conversion
Car rental near the airport	car rental mauritius airport, location voiture maurice	Online booking with value
Guesthouse in Trou aux Biches	guesthouse trou aux biches, chambre d'hôte nord maurice	Booking request, WhatsApp
Private clinic or dentist	dentist quatre bornes, implant dentaire maurice	Call, appointment form
Training centre	digital marketing course mauritius, formation excel	Enquiry form
Cake shop in Rose Hill	birthday cake rose hill, gâteau anniversaire	WhatsApp order, call

In Mauritius: seasons drive demand. Tourism peaks around European winter and school holidays; local retail peaks before Divali, Christmas and the end of the year, and around the payment of the end-of-year bonus. Plan budgets and bid targets around these moments (Section 20).

Budgets in rupees

Google Ads lets you choose the account currency when you create the account, and it cannot be changed afterwards, so choose it carefully (and check which currencies and payment methods are offered for Mauritius at that moment). In this guide all budgets are shown in Rs as illustrative examples: your real costs depend on competition for your keywords.

PART B

Strategy

Targets that make money, a structure that is easy to optimise, and tracking you can trust

SECTION 6

Setting targets that make money

Before optimising you need to know what "good" looks like. Most businesses say "we want more sales for less money". An optimiser needs exact numbers: the highest CPA you can afford and the lowest ROAS that still makes a profit.

Step 1: calculate the break-even CPA

The break-even CPA is the most you can pay for one sale before advertising starts losing money.

Example (illustrative)	Value
Average booking value (5 days of car rental)	Rs 9,000
Gross margin (after car costs, insurance, staff)	35%
Gross profit per booking	Rs 9,000 × 35% = Rs 3,150
Break-even CPA	Rs 3,150
Break-even ROAS	1 ÷ 35% = 2.86 (286%)

Step 2: choose a target with a profit cushion

If you pay exactly the break-even CPA you make no profit from that sale. Most businesses aim for a target CPA of 50–70% of break-even, or a target ROAS clearly above break-even ROAS. In the example, a target CPA of Rs 1,800 (57% of break-even) leaves Rs 1,350 of profit per booking.

Lead generation: work back from the sale

When the conversion is a lead (form, call, WhatsApp), not a sale, include the closing rate.

Example: dental clinic in Quatre Bornes (illustrative)	Value
Average profit from a new patient in year one	Rs 6,000
Share of enquiries that become patients	25%
Break-even cost per lead	Rs 6,000 × 25% = Rs 1,500
Target cost per lead (60% of break-even)	Rs 900

Step 3: compare and decide

Situation	Meaning	Typical action
CPA well below target, impression share lost to budget	Profitable and limited by money	Increase budget step by step
CPA near target	Healthy	Keep optimising quality and waste
CPA above target but below break-even	Profitable but thin	Cut waste, improve Quality Score and landing pages
CPA above break-even	Losing money on each sale	Fix urgently: pause weak keywords, review tracking and offer

Tip: lifetime value matters. A gym member who stays 18 months, or a hotel guest who comes back every year, is worth more than one sale. If you know your customer lifetime value, you can afford a higher CPA for new customers (Week 12 covers this in depth).

SECTION 7

An account structure that is easy to optimise

Week 6 showed how to build campaigns and ad groups. When you optimise, structure decides how clearly you can see problems and how much data smart bidding gets.

Principles

- **One intent per ad group:** "airport car rental" and "4x4 rental" are different needs, so they need different ads and pages.
- **Separate brand and generic campaigns:** people searching your name convert much better and cost less. Mixing them hides the real performance of generic keywords.
- **Split campaigns only when settings differ:** a different budget, location, language, bidding target or schedule. Otherwise, keep campaigns together so bidding has more data.
- **Avoid duplicate keywords** in several ad groups: they compete with each other and split the data.
- **Clear naming:** e.g. "SRCH | Generic | Car rental | EN | MU" so anyone can read reports quickly.

Too fragmented or too consolidated?

	Too fragmented	Too consolidated	Balanced
Example	40 ad groups with one keyword each, 2–3 clicks a week each	Everything in one ad group with one generic ad	5–8 themed ad groups, each with 5–20 close keywords
Problem	Too little data to learn or decide	Ads not relevant to each search: low ad relevance	Enough data and relevant ads
In Mauritius	Very common because volumes are small	Common in "DIY" accounts	The target

A sample optimised structure

```
Account: IslandWheels Car Rental (illustrative)
 |- SRCH | Brand | EN+FR | MU+FR+RE+UK        target CPA Rs 600
 |    |- Brand terms (islandwheels, island wheels rental)
 |- SRCH | Generic | Car rental | EN           target CPA Rs 1,800
 |    |- Airport car rental
 |    |- Cheap / budget car rental
 |    |- 4x4 and SUV rental
 |    |- Long-term rental (residents)
 |- SRCH | Generic | Location voiture | FR     target CPA Rs 1,800
 |    |- Location voiture aéroport
 |    |- Location 4x4 / SUV
 |- Remarketing / Performance Max (Section 24)
```

In Mauritius: when volumes are small, start with fewer campaigns. A Mauritian SME spending Rs 30,000 a month usually needs one brand campaign and one or two generic campaigns, not ten.

SECTION 8

Conversion tracking you can trust

Smart bidding, reports and every optimisation decision depend on conversion data. Week 2 showed how to set up GA4 key events and Google Tag Manager. Here you check that Google Ads receives the right conversions, with the right values.

Two ways to get conversions into Google Ads

Source	How	Good for
Google Ads conversion tag	Google tag or Google Tag Manager on the thank-you page or event	Precise ad measurement; supports enhanced conversions
Imported GA4 key events	Link GA4 and Google Ads, then import key events (formerly called "conversions" in GA4)	One source of truth with your analytics; easy to set up

Choose one as the main ("primary") action for each goal so the same booking is not counted twice.

Primary and secondary conversion actions

In **Goals → Conversions → Summary**, each conversion action is **primary** or **secondary**. Primary actions appear in the "Conversions" column and are used by smart bidding. Secondary actions appear only in "All conv." and are for observation. Make a booking, a lead form or a qualified call primary; make page views, clicks on a phone number or "add to cart" secondary.

Conversion quality checklist

- ☐ Every important action is tracked: online booking or purchase, lead form, call from the ad, call from the website, WhatsApp click
- ☐ Each action is counted correctly: "Every" for purchases, "One" for leads (one lead per click)
- ☐ Values are set: real revenue for sales; an estimated value for leads (e.g. Rs 1,500 per qualified lead)
- ☐ No duplicates: the same booking is not tracked by both a Google Ads tag and an imported GA4 key event as primary
- ☐ Status is "Active" or "Recording conversions", not "Inactive" or "Unverified"
- ☐ Attribution model is data-driven (the default) unless you have a reason to change it
- ☐ Enhanced conversions are on and diagnostics show no errors
- ☐ Consent Mode is implemented if you have visitors from Europe (Section 9)

Enhanced conversions

Enhanced conversions improve measurement by sending **hashed** first-party data (for example the email address or phone number the customer typed in your form) together with the conversion. Hashing (SHA-256) turns the data into a code that cannot be read. Google matches it with signed-in Google accounts to connect more conversions to ad clicks, even when cookies are missing.

1. In Google Ads, go to **Goals → Conversions → Settings** and turn on enhanced conversions; accept the customer data terms.
2. Choose the method: Google tag (automatic detection or code), Google Tag Manager, or the API.
3. Check the diagnostics after about 72 hours; Google says impact results appear after about 30 days.

4. Since April 2026, enhanced conversions for web and for leads use a single on/off setting.

Calls, WhatsApp and offline sales

- **Calls from ads:** use a call asset with a Google forwarding number and count calls longer than a set duration (for example 60 seconds).
- **Calls from the website:** track clicks on "tel:" links as a secondary action, or use website call conversions with a forwarding number.
- **WhatsApp:** track clicks on wa.me links as an event in Google Tag Manager (Week 2). It is a click, not a confirmed sale, so give it a lower value.
- **Offline sales:** if bookings are confirmed by phone or in the office, import them later with the click ID (GCLID) or with enhanced conversions for leads.

> Bad tracking is the most common problem found in Mauritian accounts: "conversions" that are page views, duplicate counting, or no values. Fix tracking before you touch bids, or smart bidding will optimise for the wrong thing.

SECTION 9

Consent and privacy

Remarketing, Customer Match and enhanced conversions all use personal data. Using them legally and ethically protects your customers and your account.

The Data Protection Act 2017 (Mauritius)

The Mauritian Data Protection Act 2017 is enforced by the Data Protection Office, headed by the Data Protection Commissioner. Key points for advertisers:

- **Registration:** every controller or processor of personal data must register with the Data Protection Commissioner and renew every three years.
- **Consent** must be freely given, specific, informed and unambiguous, given by a statement or a clear action (not a pre-ticked box).
- **Direct marketing:** people have the right to object to direct marketing, including related profiling, and you must tell them about this right clearly. Once they object, stop using their data for marketing.
- **Data breaches** must be notified to the Commissioner without undue delay and, where possible, within 72 hours.

Google Consent Mode v2

Consent Mode passes the visitor's cookie choices to Google tags. Version 2 uses four signals: **ad_storage**, **analytics_storage**, **ad_user_data** (can user data be sent to Google for advertising?) and **ad_personalization** (can it be used for personalised ads such as remarketing?). Since March 2024, Google requires it for advertisers who want to keep measuring and remarketing to users in the European Economic Area (EEA).

	Basic mode	Advanced mode
If the visitor accepts	Tags run normally	Tags run normally
If the visitor refuses	Tags do not load at all	No cookies, but anonymous "cookieless pings" are sent
Conversion modelling	Limited	Better: Google models missing conversions from the pings

> **In Mauritius:** a hotel, tour operator or car rental in Mauritius often has many website visitors from France (including Réunion, which is part of the EU), Germany and other European countries. Those visitors are covered by EU rules. Use a cookie banner (consent management platform) that supports Consent Mode v2, so your remarketing lists and conversion data keep working.

Good practice for remarketing and Customer Match

- ☐ A clear privacy policy that explains the use of cookies, remarketing and sharing data with advertising partners
- ☐ A cookie banner with a real "Refuse" option, connected to Consent Mode
- ☐ Customer lists uploaded only for people who gave consent, with a working way to unsubscribe
- ☐ No sensitive categories (health conditions, religion, financial difficulty) used for personalised ads: Google’s personalised advertising policy restricts this
- ☐ Remove people from lists when they ask, and refresh lists regularly

PART C

Quality, ads & audiences

Improve Quality Score, clean your search terms, strengthen ads and assets, and set up remarketing

SECTION 10

Improving expected CTR

Expected CTR estimates how likely people are to click your ad when it shows for a keyword, compared with other advertisers. It is based on past performance, adjusted for position and other factors.

Ten ways to raise your click-through rate

1. **Put the keyword idea in Headline 1 or 2:** "Airport Car Rental Mauritius" for the airport ad group.
2. **Give a reason to click now:** price, offer, guarantee or speed ("From Rs 1,500/day", "Free cancellation").
3. **Show proof:** ratings, years in business, number of customers ("4.8/5 from 900 reviews" only if true).
4. **Speak to the searcher's situation:** tourists want airport pick-up; residents want long-term rates.
5. **Add all relevant assets:** sitelinks, callouts, snippets, images and call assets make the ad bigger.
6. **Remove irrelevant searches** with negatives: they create impressions without clicks and pull CTR down.
7. **Tighten match types** where broad match brings too many loosely related searches.
8. **Write in the searcher's language:** a French ad group with French ads for "location voiture".
9. **Use clear calls to action:** "Book online in 2 minutes", "Get a free quote", "Chat on WhatsApp".
10. **Test, then keep the winner:** new headlines in an ad variation or an experiment (Section 22).

Before and after

	Weak ad	Stronger ad
Headline 1	Welcome to IslandWheels	Airport Car Rental Mauritius
Headline 2	Best Service	From Rs 1,500 per Day
Headline 3	Contact Us Today	Free Pick-up at SSR Airport
Description	We are a leading company with many cars. Call us for more info.	New cars, full insurance, no hidden fees. Book online in 2 minutes and pay on arrival.

> **Tip:** a low CTR on a keyword with a good Quality Score is not always a problem: it may be a broad research keyword. Judge by conversions and CPA first.

SECTION 11

Improving ad relevance

Ad relevance measures how closely your ad matches the intent behind the search. "Below average" usually means the ad group mixes different themes, so the ads are too general.

How to fix "Below average" ad relevance

1. **Sort keywords by Quality Score** and list those with Below average ad relevance.
2. **Check the ad group theme:** do all keywords mean the same thing? If not, move the odd ones to a new ad group.
3. **Rewrite headlines** so several of them contain the main keyword theme (not stuffed, but clear).
4. **Match the offer:** a keyword about "cheap" needs a message about price; "luxury" needs a premium message.
5. **Use the searcher's words:** read the search terms report (Section 13) and reuse the exact phrases people type.
6. **Consider keyword insertion** carefully, for example {KeyWord:Car Rental}, only when every keyword reads well in the ad.

Example: splitting an ad group

Before: "Car rental" (one ad group)	After: three ad groups
car rental mauritius, 4x4 rental mauritius, monthly car rental, airport car hire, cheap car rental, suv rental	**Airport:** airport car hire, car rental airport mauritius **4x4 / SUV:** 4x4 rental mauritius, suv rental **Long term:** monthly car rental, long term car rental

Each new ad group gets its own RSA with headlines about its theme, and its own landing page if possible (Section 12).

SECTION 12

Improving landing page experience

Landing page experience estimates how relevant and useful your page is for people who click your ad. Google looks at whether the page matches the search, is easy to use (especially on mobile), loads quickly and is transparent.

Landing page checklist

- ☐ The page matches the ad: the airport ad lands on the airport rental page, not the home page
- ☐ The headline repeats the promise of the ad (same offer, same price)
- ☐ The main action is visible on mobile without scrolling: Book, Call, WhatsApp, Get a quote
- ☐ The page loads fast on mobile: test it in PageSpeed Insights (Week 2), aim for LCP of 2.5 seconds or less
- ☐ Prices, conditions and contact details are clear; no hidden fees
- ☐ Trust signals: reviews, photos of real cars or rooms, address, registration details
- ☐ Short forms: ask only what you need (name, phone, dates)
- ☐ No pop-ups that cover the content on mobile
- ☐ Secure (https) and works in English and French if you advertise in both
- ☐ Conversion tracking fires on the thank-you page or event

One ad group, one page

The biggest landing page improvement is often simply sending each ad group to the most specific page. If the page does not exist, create one: a simple page for "4x4 rental" with the 4x4 models, prices and a booking button usually beats the home page.

Measure the page itself

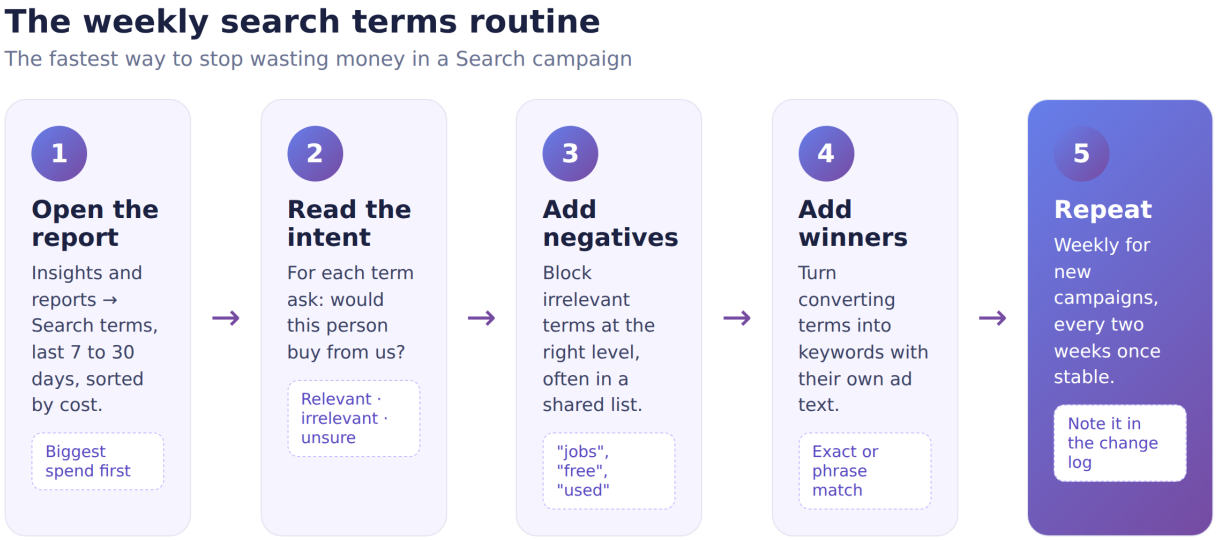
Where	What to check
Google Ads → Landing pages report	Clicks, conversions and "Mobile speed score" for each landing page URL
GA4 (Week 2)	Engagement rate and key events by landing page, filtered on google / cpc
PageSpeed Insights	Core Web Vitals on mobile
Microsoft Clarity (free)	Heatmaps and session recordings: where people stop or get stuck

> If a landing page is slow, confusing or does not match the ad, no bidding strategy can fix it. The page is part of your ad.

SECTION 13

Search terms and negative keywords

Keywords are what you bid on. Search terms are what people actually typed. With broad and phrase match (and AI Max, Section 24), your ads can show for many searches you never chose. The search terms report shows them.



How to read the report

Go to **Campaigns → Insights and reports → Search terms**. Choose the last 30 days, sort by cost and add the columns Conversions, Cost / conv. and Conv. value / cost. For each term decide:

Decision	Typical signals	Action
Relevant and converting	Conversions at or below target CPA	Add as keyword (exact or phrase) if not already one

Decision	Typical signals	Action
Relevant, not converting yet	Few clicks, matches your offer	Wait for more data
Irrelevant	Wrong product, wrong intent, wrong place	Add as negative keyword
Relevant but expensive	Many clicks, CPA far above target	Check landing page and ad; lower bid or separate it

Common negative keywords in Mauritius

Theme	Examples (adapt to your business)
Jobs	job, jobs, vacancy, vacancies, recruitment, salary, emploi, travail
Free / DIY	free, gratuit, diy, how to, tutorial, pdf
Second-hand / buying	for sale, à vendre, used, occasion, second hand (for a rental business)
Education	course, training, school, permis, driving licence (unless that is your business)
Wrong place	other countries or towns you do not serve, e.g. réunion, madagascar, rodrigues
Information only	meaning, definition, wikipedia, history

Negative keyword match types

- **Negative broad** (car sale): blocks searches containing all the words, in any order.
- **Negative phrase** ("car sale"): blocks searches containing the words in that order.
- **Negative exact** [car sale]: blocks only that exact search.
- Negative keywords do **not** automatically include close variants, plurals or misspellings: add "job" and "jobs", "location" and "locations" separately.

Negative keyword lists

Create shared lists in **Tools → Shared library → Exclusion lists** (for example "Jobs", "Free", "Competitors") and apply them to several campaigns at once. A list can hold up to 5,000 negative keywords. Be careful not to block good traffic: never add a negative without checking which keywords it could stop.

> **Wasted spend** = cost of search terms that are irrelevant to your business. Calculate it each month as a percentage of total cost: Wasted spend ÷ total cost × 100. Cutting it from 20% to 5% is often the quickest win in an audit.

SECTION 14

Ad strength and asset performance

Responsive search ads (RSAs) let Google combine your headlines and descriptions. Ad strength and the asset report help you improve them.

Ad strength

Ad strength rates each RSA as **Poor**, **Average**, **Good** or **Excellent** based on the quantity, diversity and relevance of your headlines and descriptions. It is a best-practice guide: it is not used in the auction, and an "Average" ad that converts well should not be removed just to get "Excellent".

To improve ad strength	Example
Add more unique headlines (aim for 10–15)	Price, benefit, location, proof, call to action, brand
Include popular keywords in some headlines	"Car Rental Mauritius", "Airport Car Hire"
Make headlines different from each other	Avoid "Cheap Car Rental", "Cheap Car Hire", "Low-Cost Car Rental"
Use all 4 descriptions	One for offer, one for proof, one for process, one for guarantee
Pin only when necessary	Pinning (fixing a headline in position 1) reduces combinations; use it for legal text or brand rules

The asset report

Open an ad, then **View asset details**. Since June 2025 Google shows full statistics for each headline and description: impressions, clicks, conversions and cost. (The old "Best / Good / Low" performance labels have been retired.) Google notes that asset-level numbers do not add up neatly and that ratios like CTR or CPA by asset are only directional.

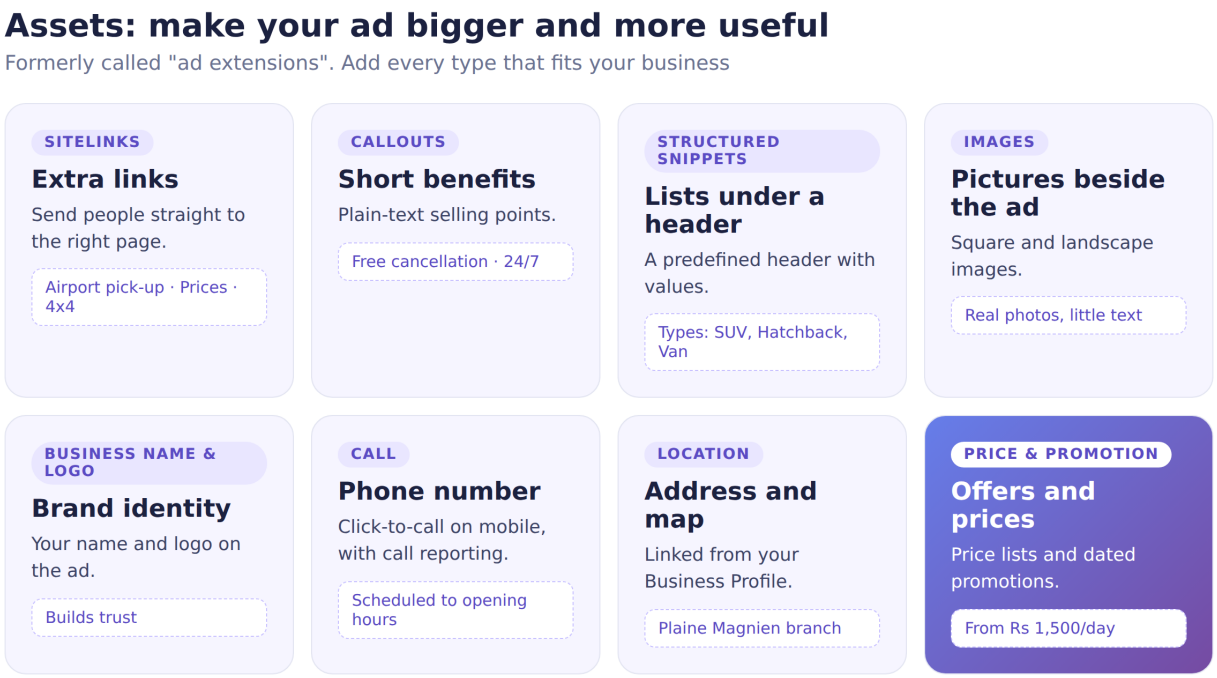
1. Look at assets with many impressions: these are the ones Google prefers.
2. Replace assets with very few impressions after several weeks: Google rarely shows them.
3. Compare messages: do price headlines get more conversions than "quality" headlines?
4. Change only 2–3 assets at a time, and note the date in your change log.
5. Check the **Combinations** report to see which headline and description combinations showed most.

> **Tip:** keep a maximum of 1–2 RSAs per ad group (Google allows up to 3 enabled RSAs). More ads split the data and slow learning, especially with Mauritian volumes.

SECTION 15

Assets: every type explained

Assets (called "ad extensions" until 2022) add extra information to your ad: links, benefits, images, phone numbers, prices. They make the ad bigger, more useful and more clickable, and Google includes their expected impact in Ad Rank.



Asset	What it shows	Key limits and tips
Sitelinks	Extra links under the ad	Link text up to 25 characters; add 2 description lines; at least 4, ideally 6–8
Callouts	Short benefits, not clickable	Up to 25 characters each; at least 4 ("Free cancellation", "24/7 assistance")
Structured snippets	A header and a list	Choose a predefined header (Types, Brands, Destinations, Services...), at least 3 values
Images	Pictures next to the ad	Square (1:1) and landscape (1.91:1); real photos; little or no text
Business name and logo	Your brand on the ad	Must match your website; reviewed by Google before it shows
Call	A phone number or call button	Schedule to opening hours; use call reporting to count calls as conversions
Location	Address, distance, map	Linked from your Google Business Profile (Week 3)
Price	Prices for services or products	Header, price, description and link for each item ("Economy car from Rs 1,500")
Promotion	A highlighted offer	Amount or percentage off, occasion (e.g. Christmas), start and end dates
Lead form	A form inside the ad	Collects leads without a website visit; connect to a CRM or download leads
App	Link to download your app	Only if you have a mobile app

Automated assets

Google can also create some assets automatically (for example dynamic sitelinks or callouts taken from your website). You can switch each type on or off in the account-level automated assets settings on the Assets page. Review them: they sometimes show outdated prices or pages.

SECTION 16

Assets: best practice and setup

Assets are free to add and you only pay when someone clicks. Most small accounts in Mauritius use only one or two types. Adding the right ones is a quick, low-risk optimisation.

Step by step: adding sitelinks

1. Go to **Campaigns → Assets**, click **+** and choose **Sitelink**.
2. Choose the level: account (all campaigns), campaign or ad group. More specific levels override general ones.
3. Write the link text (max 25 characters) and two description lines.
4. Enter the final URL: a real, specific page (Prices, Airport pick-up, 4x4 models, Reviews, Contact).
5. Optionally set a schedule or end date (for seasonal pages).
6. Save, then check the status after approval and the performance after 2–4 weeks.

Which assets for which business?

Business	Priority assets
Car rental, hotel, tour operator	Sitelinks (rooms/models, prices, reviews), callouts, images, price, promotion, call
Restaurant, cake shop	Location, call, images, callouts (delivery areas, halal, vegetarian), sitelinks (menu, order)
Clinic, lawyer, accountant	Call (in opening hours), location, structured snippets (services), callouts (experience, languages)
Training centre	Sitelinks (courses, dates, fees), structured snippets (courses), lead form, callouts (certified, evening classes)
Online shop	Price, promotion, images, sitelinks (categories), callouts (delivery across Mauritius, cash on delivery)

Best practice

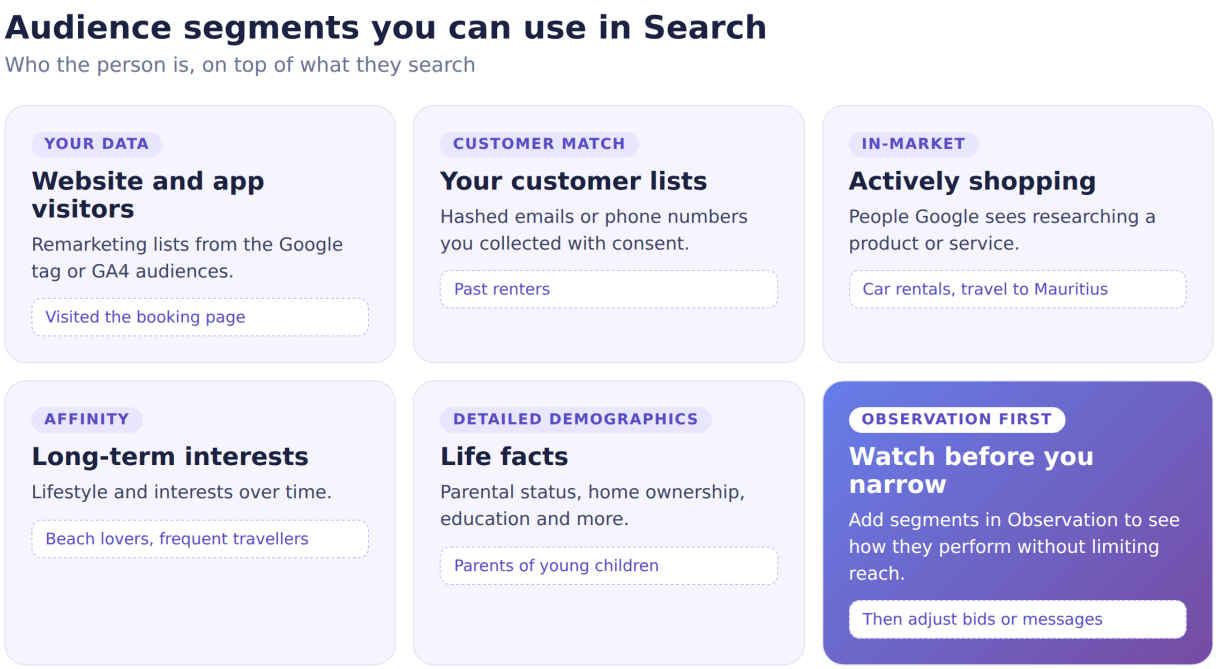
- Use **at least four asset types** per campaign where they fit.
- Make sitelinks **specific to each campaign**: the brand campaign and the 4x4 campaign need different links.
- Keep promotions and prices **up to date**: an expired offer damages trust and can break advertising rules.
- Check the **Assets report** (with "Associated with" and "Added by" columns) for performance and disapprovals.
- Write callouts as concrete facts, not vague claims: "Pick-up at SSR Airport" beats "Great service".

> **In Mauritius:** add a call asset scheduled to your real opening hours and test French versions of your sitelinks for French-language campaigns. Many Mauritian customers prefer calling or messaging over filling in a form.

SECTION 17

Audiences in Search campaigns

Keywords tell you what someone is searching for. Audience segments tell you more about who they are: a past visitor, an existing customer, someone shopping for travel. Combining both makes bidding and messages smarter.



Observation or targeting?

Setting	What it does	When to use it
Observation (recommended for Search)	Ads still show to everyone who searches your keywords; you see how each segment performs and can adjust bids or messages	Almost always, to learn: add remarketing, customer lists and in-market segments
Targeting	Ads show only to people in the selected segments who search your keywords	Special cases: broad keywords only for past visitors (RLSA), or a campaign just for existing customers

RLSA: remarketing lists for search ads

RLSA means using your remarketing lists in Search. Examples: bid higher when someone who visited your booking page searches "car rental mauritius" again; or show a special headline to returning visitors; or target broad keywords like "holiday mauritius" only for people who already know your brand.

Customer Match

Customer Match lets you upload lists of customer emails or phone numbers (hashed) to reach or exclude them. All advertisers with a good policy and payment history can use it for observation and exclusions. Targeting and bid adjustments with Customer Match need at least 90 days of Google Ads history and more than USD 50,000 lifetime spend, so many small Mauritian accounts will use it only for observation and exclusion at first. Upload only data you collected yourself, with consent (Section 9).

Exclusions

Audiences also help you **exclude** people: for example, exclude people who booked in the last 7 days from a promotion campaign, or exclude existing members from a "free trial" campaign.

> **Tip:** similar segments ("lookalikes") were retired by Google in 2023. Google's automated features such as optimised targeting and Performance Max now use your audience data as signals instead.

SECTION 18

Setting up remarketing lists step by step

Remarketing lists are now called **"your data" segments** in Google Ads. They are built from people who visited your website, used your app, watched your YouTube videos or are in your customer lists.

Before you start

- ☐ The Google tag (or a linked GA4 property) is installed on every page of the website
- ☐ Consent Mode and a cookie banner are in place (Section 9)
- ☐ Your privacy policy mentions remarketing
- ☐ Google Ads and GA4 are linked, with personalised advertising enabled in GA4 if you want to use GA4 audiences

Method 1: in Google Ads

1. Go to **Tools → Shared library → Audience manager**, then **Your data segments**.
2. Click **+** and choose **Website visitors**.
3. Name the segment clearly, e.g. "WEB | Booking page visitors | 30 days".
4. Set the rule: visitors of a page that contains "/booking" (or an event such as begin_checkout).
5. Choose the membership duration: 30 days is the default; the maximum is 540 days.
6. Choose whether to pre-fill the list with past visitors (if available), then create the segment.

Method 2: from GA4

1. In GA4 go to **Admin → Audiences → New audience**.
2. Build the condition, for example "page_location contains /booking" and "did not trigger purchase".
3. Set the membership duration and save.
4. Because GA4 is linked, the audience appears in Google Ads under Your data segments within a day or two.

Useful remarketing lists for most businesses

Segment	Rule	Duration	Use in Search
All visitors	Any page	90 days	Observation; higher bids for returning visitors
Product or service viewers	Visited a product, room or model page	30 days	Observation; specific headlines
Cart or booking abandoners	Started booking but did not finish	14 days	Higher bids; reassurance message
Converters	Completed a booking or purchase	30–180 days	Exclude from acquisition offers; target for repeat
Customer list	Customer Match upload	Refresh monthly	Observation and exclusion

List size

Since December 2025, Google lets you use remarketing and customer list segments once they reach **100 active users** on Search, Display and YouTube (the minimum used to be higher, typically 1,000 for Search). This makes remarketing far more realistic for small Mauritian websites. If a list is too small, lengthen its duration or broaden the rule.

> **In Mauritius:** a guesthouse with 2,500 visitors a month can build a useful "Visited rooms page in the last 90 days" list. Add it in observation to the generic campaign, then raise bids for those people or show them a headline like "Book direct: best price guaranteed".

PART D

Bidding, budgets & testing

Smart bidding, pacing, adjustments, experiments, recommendations, Performance Max and AI Max

SECTION 19

Smart bidding optimisation

Smart bidding uses Google’s machine learning to set a bid for every auction, based on signals such as device, location, time, the search itself and audience lists. It only works well when it receives enough correct conversion data.

The bidding ladder

Move up a step when you have enough reliable conversion data



Choosing the right strategy

Strategy	Optimises for	Use when
Maximise clicks	Most clicks for the budget	New campaigns without conversion tracking or data; always set a maximum CPC limit
Maximise conversions	Most conversions for the budget	Conversion tracking works; budget fully spent
Maximise conversions + target CPA	Conversions at an average cost you set	Roughly 15–30+ conversions a month in the campaign, stable CPA
Maximise conversion value	Most revenue for the budget	Conversions have real, different values (bookings, orders)
Maximise conversion value + target ROAS	Revenue at the return you set	Steady value data; you know your break-even ROAS
Target impression share	Being visible (top or absolute top)	Brand campaigns, protecting your name against competitors

The learning period

When you create a smart bidding strategy or change it, its status shows **"Learning"**. Google says calibration takes up to around **50 conversion events or 3 conversion cycles** (a conversion cycle is the time between the click and the conversion). Learning also starts again after changes to settings, targets or the campaign’s composition (adding or removing campaigns, ad groups or keywords). Learning continues even after the label disappears.

- Avoid big changes during learning; wait 1–2 weeks before judging.
- Change targets in steps of about 10–20%, not 50%.

- Do not change several things at once (target, budget, ads and keywords): you will not know what worked.
- In Mauritius, with fewer conversions, learning takes longer: judge over 4–6 weeks.

Setting a realistic target

1. Look at the actual CPA or ROAS of the campaign over the last 30 days (or longer if volumes are low).
2. Set the first target close to that actual value, not your dream value. A target that is too strict makes Google bid very low and spend little.
3. After 2–3 weeks, if results are stable, tighten the target by 10–15%.
4. Never set a target CPA above your break-even CPA, or a target ROAS below your break-even ROAS (Section 6).

Useful bidding tools

Tool	What it does
Portfolio bid strategies	One strategy and target shared by several campaigns: more data, better learning
Seasonality adjustments	Tell smart bidding about a short event (1–7 days) when conversion rates will change a lot, e.g. a 3-day flash sale
Data exclusions	Tell smart bidding to ignore days when conversion tracking was broken
Bid strategy report	Shows the status, top signals and the actual vs target CPA or ROAS

> Smart bidding is only as good as the conversions you feed it. If you count WhatsApp clicks as primary conversions with the same value as bookings, Google will bring you cheap clicks on WhatsApp buttons, not bookings.

SECTION 20

Budgets, pacing and impression share

Your budget decides how many auctions you can enter. Pacing means spending it smoothly across the month so you do not run out early or leave money unspent.

How Google spends a daily budget

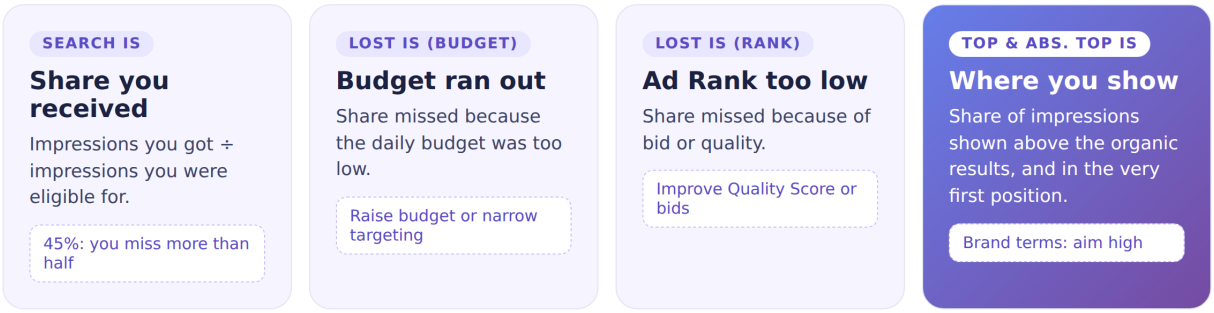
In Google Ads you set an **average daily budget**. On busy days Google can spend up to twice that amount, and less on quiet days, but over a calendar month you are not charged more than the average daily budget × 30.4 (the average number of days in a month). Example: Rs 2,000 a day can mean Rs 3,500 on a Saturday and Rs 1,200 on a Tuesday, with a monthly limit of Rs 60,800.

Monthly pacing check

Item	Example (illustrative)
Monthly budget agreed with the client	Rs 60,000
Day of the month today	15 of 30 (50% of the month)
Spend so far	Rs 36,000 (60% of the budget)
Pacing	60% ÷ 50% = 120%: overspending
Action	Reduce the daily budget to (60,000 − 36,000) ÷ 15 = Rs 1,600 for the rest of the month

Impression share: how much of the market you see

Find out whether budget or Ad Rank is holding you back



Lost to budget or lost to rank?

Add the columns **Search impr. share**, **Search lost IS (budget)** and **Search lost IS (rank)** to your campaigns table. Together they explain where your missing impressions went.

What you see	What it means	What to do
High lost IS (budget), CPA below target	A profitable campaign is running out of money	Raise the budget, or move budget from weaker campaigns
High lost IS (budget), CPA above target	Spending fast on poor traffic	Cut waste first (negatives, keywords, locations), then decide
High lost IS (rank)	Bids or quality too low	Improve Quality Score, ads and assets; review bids or targets
Low IS on brand terms	Competitors may be taking your customers	Brand campaign with target impression share or higher budget

Tip: a shared budget lets several small campaigns use one budget. It is convenient, but you lose control over how money is split. For campaigns with different values (brand vs generic), use separate budgets.

In Mauritius: plan budgets around the peaks: increase them before the high tourist season, Divali, Christmas and New Year, school holidays and Black Friday promotions, and reduce them in quiet weeks. Use the previous year’s data in Google Ads (Campaigns table, compared with the same period last year) to forecast.

SECTION 21

Ad schedule, device and location adjustments

You can control when, where and on which devices your ads appear. With manual bidding you can also raise or lower bids for each. With smart bidding, Google adjusts bids automatically, so these settings work differently.

Ad schedule

In **Campaigns → Ad schedule** you can choose the days and hours ads can show. Look at results by "Day and hour" first (Insights and reports → When and where ads showed). Typical uses:

- Run call-focused ads only when someone can answer the phone.
- Reduce spend at night if conversions at night are very poor and nobody can respond.
- Keep ads running 24/7 for online bookings and tourists in other time zones (most of Europe is 2–4 hours behind Mauritius, depending on the country and the season).

Devices

Segment your campaign by device (Segment → Device). If mobile converts much worse than computers, check the mobile landing page before lowering bids. With smart bidding, device bid adjustments are ignored, except −100% which excludes a device completely.

Locations

The location options are one of the most important and most forgotten settings. Open **Campaign settings → Locations → Location options**:

Option	Who sees your ads	Use it for
Presence or interest (default)	People in your locations, or who regularly visit them, **or** who show interest in them	Tourism: people in France searching about Mauritius
Presence	People in, or regularly in, your locations	Local businesses: a Quatre Bornes gym does not need people in Canada

Check the report **Insights and reports → When and where ads showed → Locations** ("Matched locations" vs "User locations"). You may find spend from countries you never meant to target.

> **In Mauritius:** local businesses often lose money because the default "Presence or interest" shows ads to people abroad who searched "Mauritius". Switch to "Presence" unless you want tourists. For tourism, target the source markets (France, Réunion, UK, South Africa, Germany…) separately so you can see and adjust results by country.

SECTION 22

Experiments: A/B testing in Google Ads

An experiment compares two versions of a campaign at the same time, with traffic split between them. It is the most reliable way to know if a change really works, because both versions face the same season and competitors.

What to test

Test	Example hypothesis
Bidding strategy	Maximise conversions with target CPA Rs 1,800 will bring more bookings than Maximise conversions alone
Landing page	The new airport page with prices above the fold will raise the conversion rate
Ad message	Headlines with price will get a higher CTR than headlines about quality
Match types / AI Max	Turning on AI Max will bring more conversions at a similar CPA

How to set up a custom experiment

1. Go to **Campaigns → Experiments** and click **+**; choose **Custom experiment** (or **Ad variation** for simple text changes across many ads).
2. Select the base campaign and give the experiment a clear name ("EXP | Airport LP v2 | Oct 2026").
3. Make the change in the trial version only: one change at a time.
4. Choose the split (usually 50%) and the date range: at least 4–6 weeks for most Mauritian accounts.
5. Do not edit the original or the trial during the test.
6. Read the results: Google shows the difference for each metric and whether it is statistically significant.
7. If the trial wins, apply it to the original campaign (or convert it); if not, end it and record what you learnt.

Tip: write the hypothesis and the success metric before you start: "If we use the new page, CVR will increase by at least 20% with the same CPC". This stops you from choosing the winner afterwards based on whichever number looks best.

With low volume, results may never become significant. Then use a longer test, test a bigger change, or use a before/after comparison with caution (same length of period, no other changes, check seasonality).

SECTION 23

Recommendations and optimisation score

The Recommendations page suggests changes to your account, and the optimisation score (0–100%) estimates how well your account is set to perform if you applied them. Use both critically.

How the score works

Google calculates the optimisation score in real time from your statistics, settings and the estimated impact of available recommendations. Applying or dismissing recommendations changes the score. It is **not** part of Quality Score and is not a measure of profit: a 100% account can still lose money.

Usually worth applying (after checking)	Think twice
Fix conversion tracking issues	"Raise your budget" (check CPA and lost IS budget first)
Add assets (sitelinks, callouts, images)	"Add broad match keywords" (check search terms and tracking first)
Remove redundant or conflicting keywords	"Switch to Maximise conversions" without reliable conversion data
Fix disapproved ads or policy issues	Auto-applied recommendations you have not reviewed
Improve RSA ad strength with more headlines	"Create Performance Max campaign" before Search is profitable

A safe routine

1. Review the Recommendations page weekly.
2. For each one, ask: does this help my business goal (CPA, ROAS, profit), or only Google’s reach?
3. Apply what makes sense, dismiss the rest (dismissing also raises the score).
4. Check **Recommendations → Auto-apply** and turn off anything you do not want Google to change on its own.

> **Think like an owner:** recommendations are generated for millions of accounts. They are often useful starting points, but only you know your margins, your capacity and your customers.

SECTION 24

Performance Max and AI Max for Search

Google is putting more automation into campaigns. You do not need to master these this week, but you must understand what they do, because Google will recommend them and many accounts already use them.

Performance Max (PMax)

Performance Max is a single campaign that shows ads across all Google channels: Search, Shopping, YouTube, Display, Discover, Gmail and Maps. You give it a goal, a budget, assets (text, images, videos, logos) grouped in **asset groups**, and **audience signals** (your data, customer lists, interests) as hints. Google decides where to show ads and to whom.

Recent Performance Max controls (2025)	Why it helps
Campaign-level negative keywords and negative keyword lists	Block irrelevant searches as in Search campaigns
Search terms report	See which searches triggered ads
Channel performance report	See results by channel (Search, YouTube, Display…)
Search themes (up to 50 per asset group)	Tell Google which topics matter
Device targeting and age exclusions	More control over who sees ads
Brand exclusions	Keep PMax away from your own brand searches if a brand campaign covers them

When to use it: once conversion tracking is excellent, Search campaigns are profitable and you have good images and videos. It works best for e-commerce and for businesses with clear online conversions and values. Week 16 (e-commerce) goes further.

AI Max for Search campaigns

AI Max, introduced in 2025, is **not a new campaign type**: it is a set of features you switch on inside a Search campaign. When you turn it on, it activates:

- **Search term matching:** uses broad match and "keywordless" technology (based on your assets and landing pages) to show ads for more relevant searches.
- **Text customisation** (formerly automatically created assets): generates headlines and descriptions from your ads, landing pages and website.
- **Final URL expansion:** sends people to the page on your site most likely to convert for that search, instead of the URL you chose.
- **Controls:** brand inclusions and exclusions, locations of interest at ad group level, URL inclusions and exclusions.

In reports, AI Max shows as a match type in the search terms report, with a column showing whether the match came from broad match expansion or keywordless matching.

> With Final URL expansion on, pinned RSA assets are not respected, and Google warns that AI Max will not be effective if the campaign is limited by budget. Test AI Max with an experiment (Section 22), watch the search terms report closely, and add exclusions for pages that should never be landing pages (careers, terms and conditions, blog posts).

PART E

Measurement & governance

Reporting, auction insights,
Data Studio, the full account audit
and a routine you can keep

SECTION 25

Reporting: columns, segments and Data Studio

Good reporting turns Google Ads data into decisions. Learn to customise your tables, segment the data and build simple dashboards.

Columns to add to every table

Group	Columns
Performance	Impr., Clicks, CTR, Avg. CPC, Cost
Conversions	Conversions, Conv. rate, Cost / conv., Conv. value, Conv. value / cost, All conv.
Competitive	Search impr. share, Search lost IS (budget), Search lost IS (rank), Search top IS, Search abs. top IS
Quality (keywords)	Quality Score, Exp. CTR, Ad relevance, Landing page exp.

Save a set as a custom column set (Columns → Save your column set) so you do not have to rebuild it each time.

Segments

The **Segment** button splits any table by time (day, week, month, day of week, hour), device, network, conversion action, click type and more. Example: segment the Keywords table by "Conversion action" to see which keyword brings bookings and which brings only WhatsApp clicks.

Auction insights

Auction insights (available for campaigns, ad groups and keywords) compares you with other advertisers in the same auctions:

Metric	Meaning
Impression share	Your share of impressions; also shown for competitors
Overlap rate	How often a competitor’s ad showed at the same time as yours
Position above rate	How often their ad showed above yours when both showed
Top of page rate	How often an ad showed above the organic results
Absolute top of page rate	How often an ad was the very first ad
Outranking share	How often you ranked higher than a competitor, or showed when they did not

Use it to explain changes: if your CPC rose in November and a new competitor appears with 40% overlap, competition explains part of the increase.

Data Studio dashboards

Data Studio (Google renamed Looker Studio back to Data Studio in April 2026; Week 2) connects for free to Google Ads and GA4. A one-page Google Ads dashboard usually shows:

- Scorecards: cost, conversions, CPA, conversion value, ROAS, with comparison to the previous period.
- A time series: cost and conversions by week.
- A table by campaign with CPA, ROAS and impression share.
- A table of the top search terms and keywords.

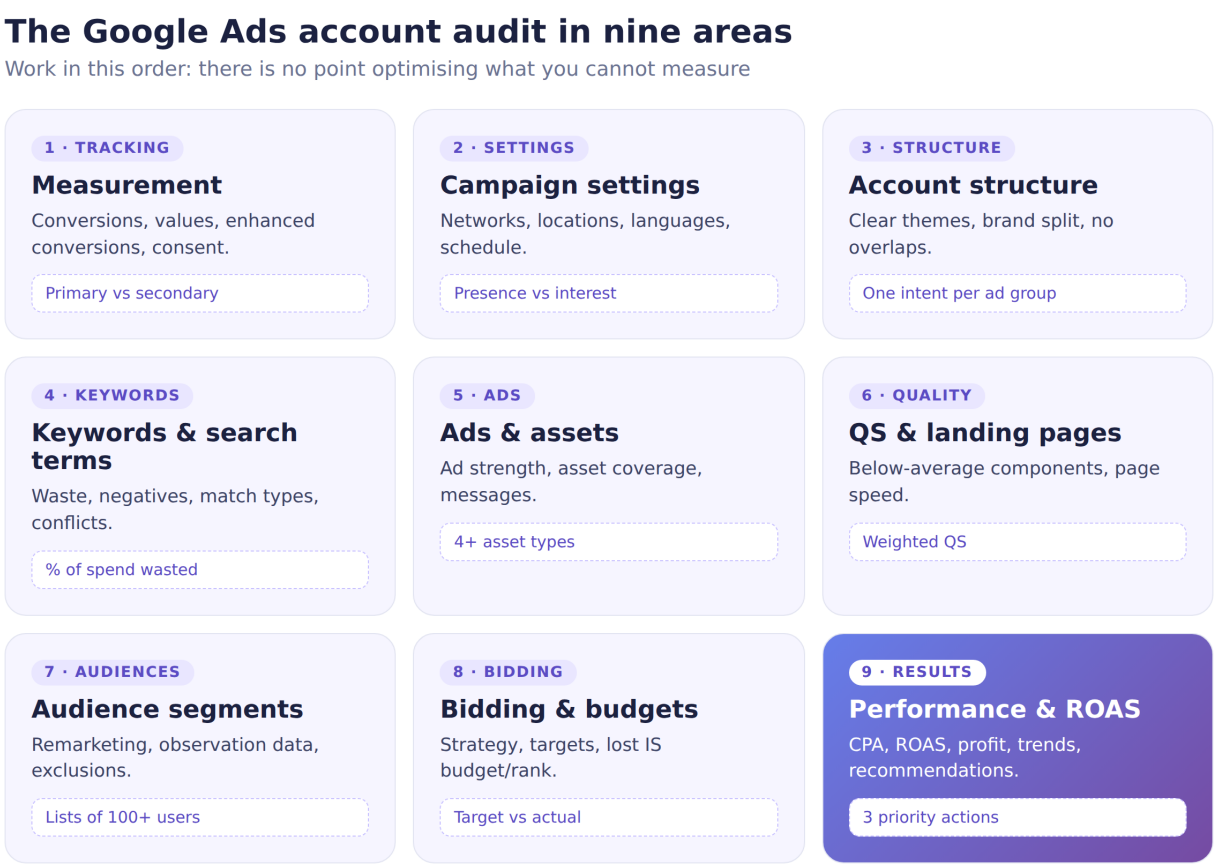
- Filters for date range, campaign and device.

Week 18 (performance reporting and data storytelling) goes further with dashboards and presentations.

SECTION 26

The account audit: step-by-step checklist

An audit is a structured health check of an account. It is the core of this week's deliverable. Work through the nine areas in order, note what you find, and finish with prioritised actions.



The checklist

1. Tracking

☐ Primary conversions are real business results (bookings, leads, qualified calls)

☐ Values are set; no duplicate counting; enhanced conversions on

☐ Consent Mode v2 for European visitors; GA4 linked

2. Settings

☐ Search campaigns do not run on the Display Network by accident

☐ Location option is correct (Presence for local businesses)

☐ Languages match the audience; ad schedule fits the business

3. Structure

☐ Brand and generic separated; one theme per ad group

☐ No duplicate keywords across ad groups; clear naming

4. Keywords and search terms

☐ Search terms reviewed for the last 30–90 days; wasted spend calculated

☐ Negative keyword lists in place and applied; no negatives blocking good keywords

☐ Keywords with high cost and no conversions identified

5. Ads and assets

☐ 1–2 RSAs per ad group, ad strength Good or Excellent, no disapprovals

☐ At least four asset types per campaign; offers and prices up to date

6. Quality Score and landing pages

☐ Weighted Quality Score calculated; keywords with Below average components listed

☐ Each ad group lands on a specific, fast, mobile-friendly page

7. Audiences

☐ Remarketing and customer lists created and added in observation

☐ Exclusions used (recent converters, existing customers where relevant)

8. Bidding and budgets

☐ Bid strategy fits the data volume; targets near actual results and within break-even

☐ Lost IS (budget) and lost IS (rank) reviewed; pacing on track

9. Results

☐ CPA, ROAS, ROI and profit calculated by campaign and compared with targets

☐ Recommendations reviewed critically; auto-apply checked

☐ Three to five prioritised actions written, with expected impact

Prioritise with an impact / effort grid

	Low effort	**High effort**
High impact	**Do now:** add negatives, fix location option, add assets, fix tracking duplicates	**Plan:** new landing pages, restructure ad groups, new bidding strategy with an experiment
Low impact	**Do when you have time:** tidy naming, pause zero-impression keywords	**Probably skip**

SECTION 27

Your optimisation routine and governance

Consistent small actions beat occasional big clean-ups. A routine also protects the account from mistakes and makes it easy to hand over to a colleague or client.

The routine

When	Tasks	Time
Daily (2–5 min)	Spend vs budget, disapproved ads, sudden drops in conversions (tracking problem?)	5 min
Weekly	Search terms and negatives, recommendations, pacing, top keywords and ads	30–60 min
Every 2–4 weeks	Quality Score review, asset report, audience performance, bid targets, landing pages	1–2 hours
Monthly	Report (CPA, ROAS, profit), auction insights, budget plan for next month	2 hours
Quarterly	Full audit (Section 26), experiments plan, structure review, seasonality planning	Half a day

Keep a change log

Google Ads keeps a **Change history** (Campaigns → Change history), but it does not say **why** you made a change. Keep a simple log in a Google Sheet: date, campaign, what changed, why, expected result, result after 2–4 weeks. When performance changes, you will know why.

Governance and security

- ☐ The business owns the Google Ads account; agencies and freelancers get access through their manager account (MCC) or as users, not ownership
- ☐ At least two admins from the business; 2-step verification on every user
- ☐ Access levels: Admin only for owners; Standard for people who edit; Read-only for viewers
- ☐ Billing profile in the company’s name; payment method and invoices checked monthly
- ☐ Remove users who leave the company or agency the same day
- ☐ Follow Google Ads policies: no misleading claims, correct prices and promotions, trademarks respected

> **Tip:** when you take over an account from someone else, download the current state (Google Ads Editor or a report export) before changing anything, so you can always go back.

PART F

Put it to work

A case study, your Performance Audit, templates, checklists and glossary

SECTION 28

Case study: a car rental company’s turnaround

"IslandWheels" is a fictional but realistic car rental company in Plaine Magnien, near Sir Seewoosagur Ramgoolam (SSR) International Airport, with 45 cars. It spent Rs 75,000 a month on Google Ads. The owner felt the ads were "too expensive" and was ready to stop. All numbers are illustrative.

1. The audit findings

- **Tracking:** WhatsApp clicks and bookings were both primary conversions with the same value. Smart bidding was chasing WhatsApp clicks. Real bookings: 25 a month.
- **Settings:** location option "Presence or interest" with Mauritius as the only target: 18% of spend came from people outside the target markets who were not travelling.
- **Search terms:** 22% of spend on irrelevant searches ("car for sale", "driving school", "bus timetable", "car rental jobs").
- **Structure:** one ad group "Car rental" with 60 keywords in English and French, one generic RSA, landing on the home page.
- **Quality Score:** weighted average 4.8; landing page experience Below average on most keywords (home page, 4.1 seconds LCP on mobile).
- **Assets:** only two sitelinks. **Audiences:** none. **Bidding:** Maximise clicks.

2. The actions (8 weeks)

Week	Action	Section
1	WhatsApp clicks made secondary; bookings primary with real revenue values; enhanced conversions and Consent Mode v2 on	8, 9
1	Location option changed to Presence; separate campaigns for Mauritius, France/Réunion and UK/South Africa	21
1	4 negative keyword lists (jobs, buying, education, transport): 180 negatives	13
2	Ad group split into Airport, Budget, 4x4/SUV, Long-term; new RSAs per theme; French campaign separated	7, 11
2	Sitelinks, callouts, structured snippets, price, image and call assets added	15, 16
3	New airport landing page: prices above the fold, booking widget, LCP 2.2 s	12
3	Remarketing segments (booking abandoners 14 days, all visitors 90 days) in observation	18
3	Bidding changed to Maximise conversion value	19
7	Target ROAS 450% added (actual ROAS of the previous 4 weeks was about 5)	19

3. Results: September (before) vs November (after)

KPI	Before	After	Formula
Cost	Rs 75,000	Rs 75,000	
Impressions	62,500	57,000	
Clicks	2,500	2,400	
CTR	4.0%	4.2%	Clicks ÷ impressions
Avg. CPC	Rs 30.00	Rs 31.25	Cost ÷ clicks
Bookings (conversions)	25	46	
Conversion rate	1.00%	1.92%	Bookings ÷ clicks
CPA	Rs 3,000	Rs 1,630	Cost ÷ bookings
Revenue (conversion value)	Rs 225,000	Rs 432,400	
ROAS	3.0 (300%)	5.77 (577%)	Revenue ÷ cost
Gross profit (35% margin)	Rs 78,750	Rs 151,340	Revenue × 35%
Profit after ad cost	Rs 3,750	Rs 76,340	Gross profit − cost
ROI	5%	102%	Profit after ad cost ÷ cost
Wasted spend	22%	6%	Irrelevant cost ÷ cost
Weighted Quality Score	4.8	6.9	SUMPRODUCT(QS, impr.) ÷ impr.
Search impression share	38%	52%	

Reading the results: fewer impressions and clicks, but much better ones. CPC rose slightly because the ads now compete for more valuable searches at the top of the page, yet CPA almost halved because the conversion rate nearly doubled. The break-even ROAS is 1 ÷ 35% = 2.86, so the account moved from barely breaking even to clearly profitable. With lost IS (budget) now the main limit and CPA well below the break-even CPA of Rs 3,150, the next step is to raise the budget for the airport campaign.

> **The lesson:** the account did not need a bigger budget or a new campaign type. It needed correct tracking, the right locations, clean search terms, relevant ads and a landing page that matched the search. Those basics doubled the bookings for the same money.

SECTION 29

Exercises and your Performance Audit

Your Week 7 deliverable is a **Performance Audit**: a campaign optimisation report with Quality Score improvements and a ROAS analysis. Work on a real account if you can (your own, your employer's or a client's, with permission and Read-only access). If not, use the IslandWheels data in the Excel exercise.

Exercise A · Metrics and targets (30 min)

For each campaign, calculate CTR, CPC, CVR, CPA, ROAS and ROI (Section 2). Calculate the break-even CPA and break-even ROAS from the average order value and margin (Section 6). Mark each campaign as profitable, thin or losing money.

Exercise B · Quality Score and search terms (60 min)

Export keywords with Quality Score and its three components. Calculate the weighted Quality Score and list the 10 highest-spending keywords with a Below average component, with a fix for each (Sections 10–12). Then review 30 days of search terms, classify them, calculate wasted spend and build at least two negative keyword lists (Section 13).

Exercise C · Assets and remarketing (45 min)

Add or plan at least four asset types for one campaign (write the texts: 4 sitelinks, 4 callouts, 1 structured snippet, a price or promotion asset). Create, or plan with exact rules and durations, three "your data" segments and say how you would use each in observation (Sections 15–18).

Exercise D · Bidding and budget plan (30 min)

Using impression share data (lost to budget and lost to rank) and CPA vs target, propose a budget reallocation between campaigns or ad groups and a bidding strategy with a target for the next month (Sections 19–20).

Deliverable: the Performance Audit

Part	Content
1. Summary	Account, period analysed, 3–5 key findings and the 3 priority actions (one page)
2. Tracking and settings	What is tracked, values, consent, location options, networks: issues found
3. Performance analysis	Table by campaign: cost, conversions, CPA, revenue, ROAS, ROI vs break-even
4. Quality Score	Weighted QS, below-average components, planned fixes and expected impact
5. Search terms	Wasted spend (Rs and %), negative lists created, new keywords
6. Ads, assets and audiences	Ad strength, asset coverage, remarketing segments
7. Bidding and budget	Impression share analysis, budget reallocation, bidding strategy and targets
8. Action plan	Impact/effort grid; actions with owner, date and KPI to check

Submit the audit (Google Doc, Slides or PDF link, 6–10 pages) on the learning platform, Module 7 exercises. Remove or blur any client names, customer data and account numbers you are not allowed to share.

TEMPLATES

Copy-and-use templates

Performance table by campaign

Campaign	Cost	Conv.	CPA	Revenue	ROAS	Profit after ads	Status
Total							

Quality Score fix list

Keyword	QS	Exp. CTR	Ad rel.	LP exp.	Cost	Fix	Done

Search terms review

Search term	Cost	Conv.	Decision	Negative / keyword added	List

Change log

Date	Campaign	Change	Why	Expected result	Result after 2–4 weeks

SECTION 30

Checklists, mistakes and glossary

Weekly optimisation checklist

- ☐ Conversions are still recording (no sudden drop to zero)
- ☐ Spend is on pace for the month
- ☐ Search terms reviewed; negatives and new keywords added
- ☐ Disapproved ads and assets fixed
- ☐ Recommendations reviewed; auto-apply checked
- ☐ Bid strategy status checked (learning, limited)
- ☐ Changes noted in the change log

Mistakes to avoid

Mistake	Do this instead
Optimising with broken or duplicated conversion tracking	Fix tracking first (Section 8)
Chasing Quality Score 10 on every keyword	Focus on high-spend keywords with Below average components
Never looking at search terms	Review them every week or two
Applying every recommendation	Apply only what fits your goals and margins
Changing bids, budgets and ads every day	Few changes, then wait for data (learning period)
Targets set far from reality	Start near actual CPA/ROAS and tighten by 10–15%
"Presence or interest" for a local business	Use "Presence" unless you want tourists
Sending all ads to the home page	One ad group, one specific landing page
Judging on ROAS alone	Calculate profit and ROI with your real margin
Remarketing without consent	Cookie banner, Consent Mode v2, privacy policy, DPA 2017

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Ad Rank	The value that decides if and where your ad shows in each auction
Quality Score	1–10 keyword diagnostic based on expected CTR, ad relevance and landing page experience
Expected CTR	How likely your ad is to be clicked, compared with other advertisers
Ad relevance	How closely the ad matches the intent of the search
Landing page experience	How relevant and useful the page is after the click
Search term	The exact words someone typed that triggered your ad
Negative keyword	A word or phrase that stops your ad from showing for certain searches
Wasted spend	Cost of clicks from irrelevant searches
Assets	Extra information on ads (sitelinks, callouts, images…), formerly "extensions"
Ad strength	Best-practice rating of an RSA: Poor, Average, Good or Excellent
Your data segments	Remarketing lists of website, app or YouTube visitors and customer lists
RLSA	Remarketing lists for search ads: using those lists in Search campaigns
Customer Match	Uploading hashed customer emails or phone numbers to reach or exclude them
Observation / targeting	Watch a segment without limiting reach / show ads only to that segment
Smart bidding	Automated bidding that sets a bid for each auction to reach a conversion goal
Target CPA / target ROAS	The average cost per conversion / return on ad spend you ask smart bidding to aim for
Learning period	Time a bid strategy needs to calibrate after it is created or changed
Impression share (IS)	Impressions received ÷ impressions you were eligible for
Break-even ROAS	1 ÷ gross margin: the ROAS at which ads neither make nor lose money
Enhanced conversions	Sending hashed first-party data with conversions to improve measurement
Consent Mode v2	Google’s system to pass visitors’ consent choices to Google tags
Optimisation score	Google’s 0–100% estimate of how well an account is set up to perform
Performance Max	One automated campaign across all Google channels
AI Max for Search	A set of automated matching, text and URL features inside Search campaigns
Auction insights	Report comparing your performance with competitors in the same auctions